GEHLOT'S GAMBIT

The inside story of how the Rajasthan chief minister mounted his rebellion against the Congress's First Family. He may have been forced into a retreat now, but not before making a point

By Kaushik Deka and Rohit Parihar

Photograph by **BANDEEP SINGH**

Son of a professional magician, Rajasthan chief minister Ashok Gehlot had learnt a few magic tricks from his father Laxman Singh Gehlot. The law graduate would even perform them on stage with Gehlot Sr before he joined politics full-time. And if his friendss and detractors are to be believed, he lost none of his magic touch after coming into the political arena, using it to navigate the various challenges in his career and emerging out of even the most hopeless situations.

This time, however, the 71-year-old veteran may have gone too far. On September 29, a day before the deadline to file nominations for the post of the Congress president was to come to an end, Gehlot announced that he will not be contesting as the Congress president, putting a cap on the week-long drama that saw him outwitting the Congress first family at every step. They had reposed their faith in him and chosen him to contest the presidential election since they perceived him as a loyalist. Gehlot was initially reluctant to accept the charge being offered, but eventually came around, apparently after a stern directive by Congress president Sonia Gandhi, but with the fond hope that he would also be allowed to retain the chief ministership. When that didn't seem likely, he agreed to relinquish that too, so long as it was not handed over to Sachin Pilot, who had been eyeing the chair ever since Gehlot came to occupy it. He was given the impression, or so he assumed, that his wish would be granted.

However, when the Congress president asked for a Congress Legislature Party to be convened on September 25, in which a one-line resolution authorising her to choose the next chief minister of Rajasthan would be passed, and asked him to resign before that meeting, Gehlot used a trick every magician deploys sooner or later in his act: illusion. He apparently suggested that the meeting be held at his official residence, since it would afford them the privacy a hotel would not. He even promised the two observers Sonia Gandhi had sent—AICC in-charge of Rajasthan Ajay Maken and Congress Working Committee (CWC) member Mallikarjun Kharge—a delicious Rajasthani dinner. The timing for the CLP meeting was fixed for 7 pm since Gehlot and two of his close confi-